



Public office is fast becoming a private stronghold, a place where accountability is an unused term, to be ignored, crushed under the weight of babudom. But change is inevitable. Whether it's through transparency in election funds, removing reservations, administering a jolt to a somnolent public sector or revamping a policing system that is still restricted to the early 20th century methods, a kinder, gentler state requires tougher, more demanding citizens.

Reservations will permanently **DAMAGE** THE PSYCHE of our youngsters. Invest, instead, in their high-quality education.

It was sometime in the first week of March 2006 that Meira Kumar, the Union Minister for Social Justice, called me to Delhi for a meeting. She was meeting various business people seeking support for legislation on reservation of jobs in the private sector for the Scheduled Castes (SC) and Scheduled Tribes (ST). In a soft, gentle, yet firm manner, she told me she was determined to ensure justice to the much neglected SC and ST youngsters in the country, and that she was keen to move a statute for reservation of jobs for them in the private sector in Parliament. She expected the industry to support her. I was equally courteous and firm in my reply. I agreed with her that enormous harm and injustice has been done to the SC and ST youngsters in the country for over 4,000 years. I told her, however, that the solution to the problem did not lie in reservation of jobs in the private sector. I ended the conversation saying that I was enthusiastic about finding a solution to this problem and I would think for a few days, and get back to her with my solution to this important national issue.

I came back to Bangalore, spent a few days thinking how the IT industry and Infosys could demonstrate their commitment to providing opportunities for such students. I wanted a scheme that did not diminish the confidence of these youngsters in this highly competitive industry, while ensuring fairness to the companies whose revenues came primarily

from developed countries and whose customers did not appreciate the social problems of our country. I have always believed that aspiration, hard work, discipline and commitment can make any person, from any social background, succeed, as long as society provides an opportunity to him to demonstrate these values. I realised that the best way to demonstrate that our underprivileged are as good as anybody else was to create a Special Training Programme (STP) to train 100 such students and show that they would get software engineering jobs in major software companies through the same selection procedure as is used by these corporates at campus recruitments.

Generally, when I have a good idea, I discuss it with my extraordinary Infosys colleague Mohandas Pai. When I discussed it with him this time, he was very enthusiastic and suggested that we bring in M.P. Ravindra, head of education and research at Infosys, and also S. Sadagopan, director at the International Institute of Information Technology, Bangalore (IIIT-B), in order to make it a bilateral programme. Sadagopan came out with a well-thought seven-month-long training programme. When the four of us met, I laid down the following ground rules for this pilot:

- ▶ The selection procedure would be left to the Karnataka Government since we wanted it to be a genuine and not a rigged experiment in enabling the disadvantaged.
- ▶ The best and the most committed teachers from Infosys and IIIT-B would have to be

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ENGINEERING GRADUATES
FROM SC AND ST
COMMUNITIES
PARTICIPATED IN A
SPECIAL TRAINING
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